3.4 Enrollment

Enrollment is the process that establishes a relationship and sets up the mechanisms necessary for recognizing and remembering the entity described by the account. Since enrollment is foundational to any digital relationship, let’s dive a little deeper into the details of how enrollment works.

3.4.1 Self-service vs. admin-driven enrollment

The first important aspect of enrollment to consider is whether enrollment is self-service or driven by some administrative process. Most of us have hundreds of accounts at various places online and thus have experienced self-service enrollment more times than we’d like to remember. In this familiar process, discovery is often prompted by a marketing message, something the enrollee has read, or a recommendation from a friend.

After finding the right service, the instigator clicks on Create Account and is taken through a series of steps designed to select an identifier, establish a means of authentication (usually a password), and collect any needed attributes. Nowadays, almost every system uses email as the identifier because it’s guaranteed to be unique, saving time spent checking the person’s choice of identifier for uniqueness and forcing them to choose another if it’s not.

Administrative enrollment occurs when a system or administrator initiates and manages the enrollment process, so discovery is usually straightforward. In non-self-service enrollments, discovery is dependent on the type of service. This kind of enrollment is common in enterprise environments, regulated industries, and managed IT systems. Concrete examples include employee onboarding, contractor or vendor management, device enrollment in managed IT environments, and cloud service enrollment when new services are created.

In administrative enrollment situations, the identifier is often created for the enrollee, and the administrator chooses initial authentication credentials. These credentials are usually communicated to the enrollee using an out-of-band process. If these are user credentials, they usually come with the